

Bodhan AI launched for Indic languages



Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Madras-incubated Bodhan AI – a Centre of Excellence focused on artificial intelligence (AI) for education -- has introduced four key AI models designed for Indian languages, in partnership with AI4Bharat and Nvidia. The models cover speech recognition, speech generation, machine translation, and optical character recognition (OCR). They are available as open weights and hosted application programming interfaces (APIs) on sovereign digital infrastructure, enabling startups, edtech firms, researchers and government bodies to build customised applications.

Together, these models form part of the Bharat EduAI Stack, which Bodhan AI envisions as a shared digital public infrastructure for India's multilingual education system. The goal is to prevent duplication of effort, so institutions don't have to rebuild the same AI tools separately for different languages. As Prof. Mitesh Khapra, principal investigator at Bodhan AI explained, Bodhan AI wants to "build with the ecosystem, not compete with it," offering a common technology layer for education-focused AI.

The models were trained using Nvidia's Nemotron open libraries, including the NeMo framework and optimised to handle Indian languages, dialects, and accents. They are deployed with Nvidia TensorRT-LLM and vLLM microservices. Bodhan AI and Nvidia are also collaborating on datasets and training recipes for future language models.

Potential applications include voice-enabled AI tutors and tools that can read and interpret educational material in multiple Indian languages. Bodhan AI is already launching two products based on these models: the 'Student Tutor Bot' and the 'Teacher Assistant Bot'. Importantly, teachers remain in control, with AI-generated content serving only as a draft to be reviewed or edited. Prof. V. Kamakoti, director of IIT Madras, emphasised that India's AI efforts must prioritise technology that respects its linguistic diversity.

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India's top universities and technical institutes have spent at least ₹ 1.34 billion in the past five years on proprietary software licences, according to figures compiled through Right to Information queries by a free and open source software (FOSS) collective. The advocacy group warns the real number is likely far higher, since the data covers only 15-20 per cent of premier public institutes and excludes the Indian Institutes of Technology (IITs).

The spending spans email systems, engineering and electronic design automation (EDA) tools for chip design, and digital assignment platforms. "Institutions spend crores every year teaching students software they will never own," the group noted, arguing that dependence on proprietary platforms undermines both technology sovereignty and student learning. FOSS United CEO Sai Rahul Poruri cautioned that vendors could revoke access at any time, exposing universities to serious risks. He added that India's push for sovereignty is being applied too narrowly, ignoring broader dependence on foreign tech.

Despite government policies encouraging open source adoption, proprietary 'lock-in' continues to dominate campus decisions. FOSS advocacy groups call for a shift towards open source alternatives in curricula, positioning them as critical for India's long-term independence and innovation.

As costs rise and sovereignty debates intensify, the choice between proprietary and open source software is set to become a defining issue for the future of Indian higher education.